

EDWIN SOCRATES LARA

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Designer & AI Builder with 10+ years of experience across fintech, e-commerce, and workforce development, focused on AI products, conversational interfaces, and agentic workflows. Works end to end from user research and prototyping through production code, designing and building products from early ideas to shipped experiences.

EXPERIENCE

FutureFit AI

Designer & AI Builder

Toronto, Ontario

Oct 2025 – Present

- Design and build AI products for a workforce platform serving businesses and governments. Worked across research, product, design, AI prototyping, data integrations, and production code.
- **Miles:** Designed and shipped the core UX/UI for FutureFit's trained LLM, including conversational flows for career exploration, job discovery, and understanding fit for specific roles. Integrated Miles across the platform through contextual prompts and AI actions.
- **SideBar:** Built an LLM-powered networking coach that helps job seekers activate their existing networks. In testing, 90% reached outreach, 80% would send the AI-drafted message as-is or with minor edits, and most said they were likely to use the coach again. Piloted for the Christensen Institute's Prosocial Possibilities research cohort, which selected FutureFit AI as one of 10 edtech providers studying how technology can strengthen social connection and expand access to opportunity.
- **Ideas Dashboard:** Designed and built an AI prioritization system that evaluates customer feedback against company strategy and technical architecture, surfacing 10 priorities each week and quick wins for the team to build.
- **AI Evidence Layer:** Built integrations across Canny, Clarify, and Heap using Claude Code and LLMs to synthesize customer feedback, client conversations, and behavioral data into evidence for product decisions.
- **Design System:** Built an AI-compatible design system with design tokens and shadcn/ui, enabling code-generation tools to assemble interfaces from established components. Shipped WCAG, ARIA, and Cypress accessibility improvements directly to production.

Complex NTWRK

Lead Product Designer

Toronto, Ontario

Apr 2022 – Oct 2025

- Spearheaded the design and launch of the "Auctions" feature, directly contributing to 63% of company revenue and achieving 23% quarterly growth, a 172% increase in chat messages per show, and 5-minute increase in average show watch time.
- Designed and iterated the Seller Dashboard, a critical product management and order fulfillment tool utilized by 400+ sellers to process 106,372+ orders, generating over \$10,500,000+ in total revenue.
- Led the end-to-end design integration during acquisition of Complex, merging e-commerce and media into a unified platform.

Super.com

Senior Product Designer

Toronto, Ontario

Nov 2021 – Apr 2022

- Led the UX design for SuperCash credit-building cashback card, achieving 50,000+ cards issued within 7 months of launch.
- Shipped MVP of unified "super app," integrating hotel booking, e-commerce and financial services post-rebrand to Super.com.

Backbase

Senior Product Designer

Toronto, Ontario

Nov 2020 – Nov 2021

- Directed the full lifecycle UX/UI and technical integration of Backbase's platform across NA and EU financial institutions, customizing solutions for regional compliance and needs.
- Facilitated cross-functional teams (development, product, compliance) to navigate complex integration challenges, ensuring the delivery of scalable and user-centric digital banking solutions.

Meridian Credit Union

Senior Product Designer

Toronto, Ontario

May 2019 – Nov 2020

- Led the redesign of the Meridian Credit Union mobile app for 370,000+ customers, significantly enhancing usability, engagement and improving retention.
- Established a comprehensive IA and design system to ensure a cohesive and user-friendly digital banking experience.
- Conducted extensive user-centric research, including user testing and surveys, and analyzed key data to inform design decisions and understand specific consumer banking behaviors.

Contracting

Product Designer

Toronto, Ontario

Dec 2015 – May 2019

Fintech

- **Bank of Montreal:** Led the end-to-end redesign of the bank's entire public website and core navigation to better direct users to the bank's products.
- Toronto-Dominion Bank: Led redesign initiatives for MBNA credit card application process, enhancing user experience and optimizing the user's credit card application journey.

Viafoura

- Spearheaded the design of a commenting and chat tool utilized by USA Today, The Telegraph, The Globe and Mail, CBC, The Independent, and Dow Jones and many more to help foster community engagement on their websites.
- Developed a data segmenting and insights tool that tracks user behaviour and engagement to help media publishers understand user preferences.

Volkswagen

- Conceptualized and designed a car comparison tool for Volkswagen that serves over 112,000 customers per month to date.

SKILLS & METHODOLOGIES

AI & LLM work: Claude API, OpenAI API, Prompt and persona engineering, LLM output validation, Vercel AI SDK, Claude Code, Cursor, v0, Lovable, Claude Design

Build & ship: TypeScript, React, Next.js, Node, Python, Supabase / PostgreSQL, Vercel, Vite, Tailwind, Git, GitHub, shadcn/ui, S3, Agile/Scrum

Integrations: REST APIs built from scratch (Canny, Jira, Clarify), GraphQL, Slack apps, Scheduled jobs

Design: Design systems, Design tokens, Figma, Framer, Storybook, Information architecture, Prototyping, Design thinking, Product strategy, UX strategy, Miro, Aura Build, Lottie Lab, Magic Animator, Jitter

Research & analytics: User research, A/B testing, Heap, Hotjar, Contentsquare, Maze, UserTesting, Useberry, SQL

Accessibility: WCAG 2.2 AA auditing and remediation, axe, Screen-reader semantics

EDUCATION

Graduate Diploma, Interactive Design

CFC Media Lab, Toronto, Ontario, Canada

Certificate, Graphic Design

Toronto School of Art, Toronto, Ontario, Canada

Diploma, Advertising

Sheridan College, Oakville, Ontario, Canada